

TANKS AND ARMoured VEHICLES

With the deadly combination of artillery, machine-guns, and barbed wire dominating the battlefield, the “poor bloody infantry” could not function effectively without some form of adequate protection in attack. The support offered by motor vehicles was limited due to their unreliability and difficulty in manoeuvring under all but ideal conditions. This led to the development of a form of armoured tractor that could run on continuous tracks rather than wheels, and had sufficient armour to be impervious to bullets and shrapnel. “Tanks”, as they came to be called, were first deployed during the Battle of the Somme, in 1916, but it was not until the following year, at Cambrai, that they were first used with any real degree of success.



◀ TANK CREW HELMET

Date	1916
Origin	UK
Material	Steel, leather

Bullets striking the tank caused metal splinters to fly. British tankers were thus issued with these leather-covered steel helmets.

Goggles

Mail face mask

▼ “LITTLE WILLIE”

Date	1915	Origin	UK
Weight	18.3 tonnes (20.2 tons)		
Length	6.53m (21½ft)		
Top speed	3kph (2mph)		
Engine	78.3kW (105hp)		

“Little Willie” was a prototype armoured fighting vehicle that was built to prove the viability of the concept to British military chiefs.

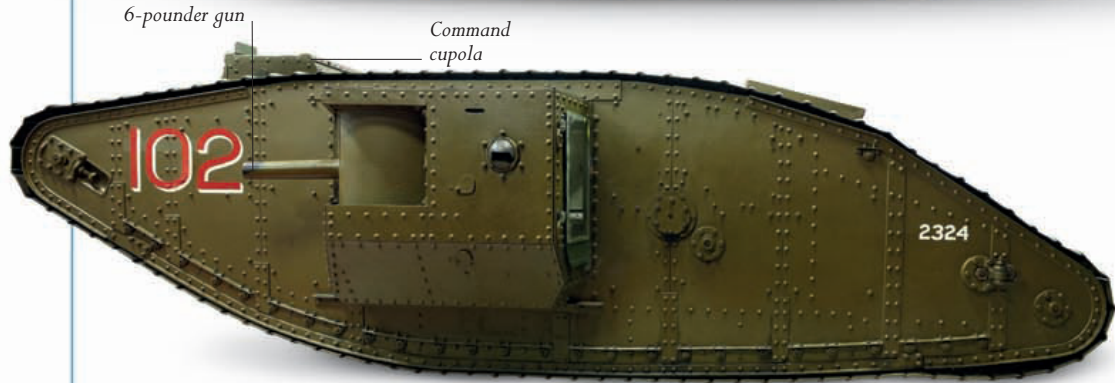


6mm mild steel bodywork

Track tensioner

Hotchkiss machine-gun

Continuous “caterpillar” track driven from the front



6-pounder gun

Command cupola

◀ MARK IV TANK

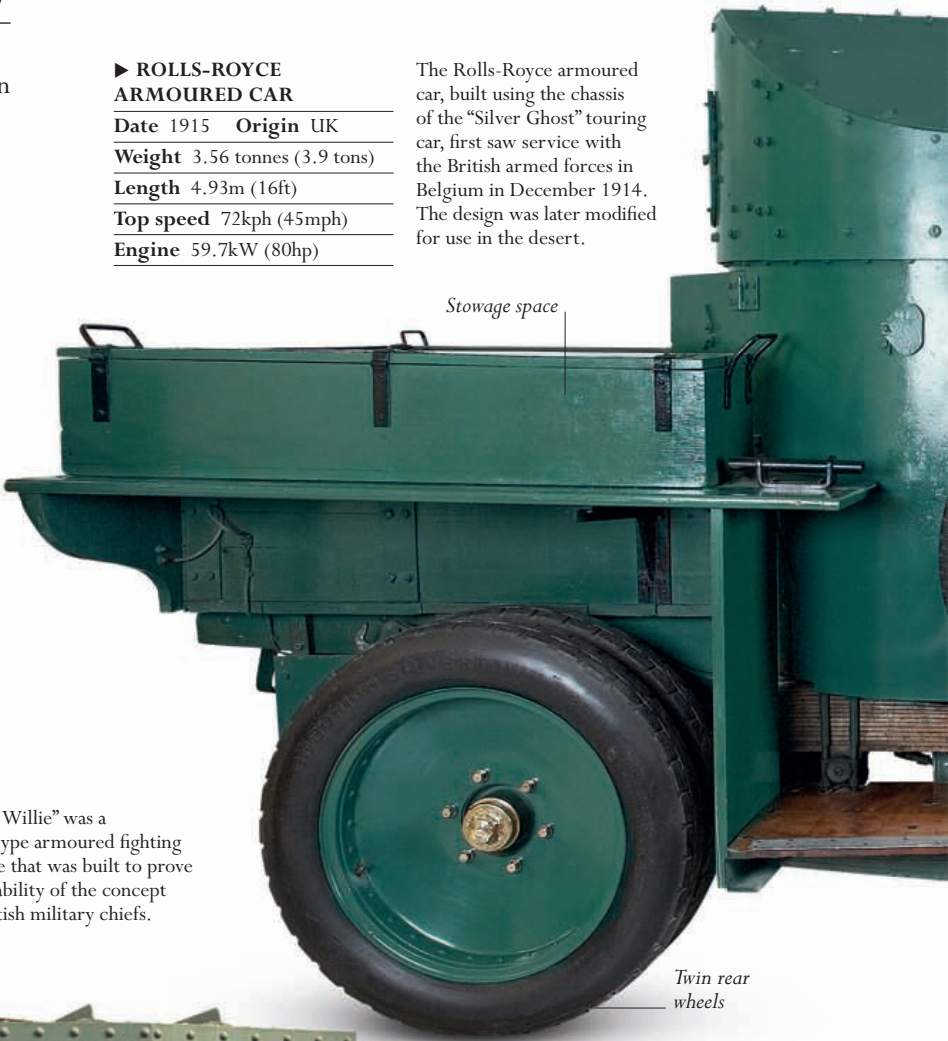
Date	1917	Origin	UK
Weight	28.4 tonnes (31.4 tons)		
Length	8.02m (26¼ft)		
Top speed	6kph (4mph)		
Engine	78.3kW (105hp)		

The improved Mark IV tank was built in large numbers. Crew safety was ensured by moving the petrol tank to the outside of the vehicle, a measure that also improved ventilation and comfort.

► ROLLS-ROYCE ARMoured CAR

Date	1915	Origin	UK
Weight	3.56 tonnes (3.9 tons)		
Length	4.93m (16ft)		
Top speed	72kph (45mph)		
Engine	59.7kW (80hp)		

The Rolls-Royce armoured car, built using the chassis of the “Silver Ghost” touring car, first saw service with the British armed forces in Belgium in December 1914. The design was later modified for use in the desert.



Stowage space

Twin rear wheels